

LUMBAR VERTEBRAE

These bones are sturdy and have a large circular area, helping to carry the weight that pushes down from your upper body.

The breastbone (sternum) is at the front of the ribcage.

The ribs curve forward from the backbone.

A flexible cartilage connects each rib to the sternum.

The floating ribs are not attached to your breastbone.

Backbone

Lumbar bones

Sacrum

Coccyx

SHOCK ABSORBERS

Sandwiched between each bone is a tough, springy disk of cartilage. The disks squash slightly under pressure to absorb shocks when you run or jump, allow small bending and twisting movements, and prevent the bones from rubbing against each other.

Each bone can twist slightly in both directions.

Your spinal cord runs through this space.

The disk squashes to absorb knocks.

A springy ligament between each bone helps control movement.

ORGAN PROTECTOR

Your backbone provides a strong anchor for your ribcage. This cage-like structure consists of 12 pairs of curved ribs, each attached to your backbone. The ribcage helps protect your delicate organs, such as the heart, lungs, and liver.

